



What the Waiting Did

Student copy (project or hand out)

The following is a reflective essay on the disappearance of waiting from everyday life, addressed to a general reader. The writer first grants the gains of a world without delay, then turns to ask what was quietly lost along with it.

1 Waiting used to be the ordinary weather of a life. You wrote a letter and waited weeks for the reply. You wanted a song and waited for the radio to play it. You missed a fact and waited, sometimes for years, to learn it. None of this was a virtue. It was the plain cost of being alive, back before that cost was quietly abolished.

2 The abolition is a gift, and it would be foolish to pretend otherwise. A parent now reaches a child in a held breath. A test result arrives before the dread has time to settle. The busy signal, the layaway counter, the long line at the bank: speed has retired a hundred small daily humiliations, and almost nobody who lived through them misses the waiting itself. We bought back the time we used to lose, and we were right to want it.

3 And yet something went out of the world along with the waiting, something we were never given a price for. The wait had never been only an absence; it was a room. Inside that room the mind did its slow and unsupervised work, rehearsing and dreading and hoping and changing its own position before anyone else could watch. The letter you waited three weeks for was answered, in part, by the three weeks. Boredom, the most maligned of states, was often just thinking with the lights off.

4 We did not only lose the wait; we lost what the wait used to make in us. Patience, yes, but also the second thought, the cooled temper, the letter never sent. Speed keeps its promises. It is the promises of slowness that go unrecorded, because a thing that never happens leaves behind no receipt.

5 So the real question is not whether to go back. Nobody is going back, and the radio is not returning to make us wait for the song. We are very good now at not waiting. The question is smaller, and harder. It is whether a life that need never pause has quietly stopped doing the work that only the pause once did. And whether we would even notice the loss now, with nothing left in the day to make us wait for it.

Close-reading multiple choice:

1. The relationship between the second paragraph and the third paragraph is best described as one in which the writer first
 - A) offers a tentative claim and then supplies the evidence that confirms it
 - B) praises the arrival of speed and then predicts that its benefits will soon fade
 - C) states a personal grievance and then broadens it into a shared complaint
 - D) grants the full value of speed and then identifies a cost that value had concealed
2. Which of the following best characterizes the writer's overall attitude toward the disappearance of waiting?
 - A) Nostalgically certain that life before instant access was richer and ought to be restored
 - B) Coolly neutral, laying out the trade-off without signaling a preference either way
 - C) Sharply alarmed, warning that the end of waiting has already done irreversible harm
 - D) Genuinely appreciative of speed yet uneasy that an unnoticed loss may have come with it

Discussion questions:

1. The writer spends a whole paragraph agreeing that almost no one misses waiting before arguing that we lost something real. How does conceding the other side first change the way the later claim lands?
2. The essay reframes waiting as “a room” where the mind works. Find one other place where the writer turns an abstract idea into something concrete, and explain what that lets the reader see or feel.

Writing prompt (homework or extended in-class, argument essay):

The writer suggests that a life that “need never pause” may have “quietly stopped doing the work that only the pause once did.” Defend, challenge, or qualify the claim that something valuable is lost when waiting disappears from everyday life. Use your own knowledge, observation, or reading.